TINY JAPANESE · WORKBOOK

Katakana Starter

Read every katakana character in 11 short lessons.

Beginner · 11 lessons · Reading & writing

How to use this workbook. Follow the lessons on the website (with the short video for each one), and keep this workbook next to you. Read each page, say everything out loud, do the writing practice and tick your answers in "Check yourself". The answer key is at the back.

Website: tiny-japanese.sabagh1.workers.dev

LESSON 1 OF 11 · 20 MIN

Meet Katakana: Vowels and the K Row

Goal: Read ア イ ウ エ オ and カ キ ク ケ コ, and use ー to read your first words.

What is katakana?

Katakana is the second Japanese script. It has exactly the same 46 sounds as hiragana, written with different, sharper shapes. If you can read ア as “a”, you already know how to say it. Only the shapes are new.

Katakana is used mostly for words borrowed from other languages (コーヒー, “coffee”), foreign names, and for emphasis, a bit like italics. It is also used for sound effects and many food and drink names, so you will see it on every menu and in every convenience store.

The five vowels

ア	イ	ウ	エ	オ
a	i	u	e	o

The K row

カ	キ	ク	ケ	コ
ka	ki	ku	ke	ko

Look-alikes to watch

ア and オ
Both have a crossing stroke. ア is simpler: a bar with a hook. オ has a longer vertical stroke running through the cross bar.

ウ and ク
ウ has a small top dot stroke over a roof shape. ク is a sideways hook with no dot. Say each out loud as you write them.

The long vowel mark: ー

A line that stretches the vowel
In katakana, a long vowel is written with a short line ー instead of repeating the vowel. ケーキ is “keeki” (cake), with the e held for two beats. In horizontal text the line is horizontal, in vertical text it turns vertical.

Your first words

JAPANESE	ROMAJI	MEANING

オーケー	ookee	OK
カー	kaa	car
キー	kii	key
ケーキ	keeki	cake
コーク	kooku	cola (Coke)

How to practise

- Say each sound out loud as you read it. You already know the sounds from hiragana, so this is only about new shapes.
- Write each new character about ten times, following a reliable stroke-order chart. Writing helps you notice the small differences between look-alike characters.
- Read the words aloud and guess what they are before checking the meaning. Most katakana words come from English, so you will often get them right.

Writing practice

Trace the grey characters, then write each one on your own. Say the sound out loud every time. Check the stroke order in this lesson's video.



ke ケ ケ ケ

ko コ コ コ

Check yourself

1. How do you read エ?

◯ A. i ◯ B. u ◯ C. e

2. How do you read ウ?

◯ A. o ◯ B. ku ◯ C. u

3. How do you read オ?

◯ A. ko ◯ B. ke ◯ C. o

4. How do you read キ?

◯ A. a ◯ B. ki ◯ C. o

5. Which character is “ka”?

◯ A. コ ◯ B. カ ◯ C. イ

6. Which character is “ko”?

◯ A. エ ◯ B. ケ ◯ C. コ

7. Which character is “ku”?

◯ A. オ ◯ B. エ ◯ C. ク

8. What does オーケー mean?

◯ A. key ◯ B. OK ◯ C. car

9. What does キー mean?

◯ A. cola (Coke) ◯ B. cake ◯ C. key

10. How do you read カー?

◯ A. ookee ◯ B. kaa ◯ C. kii

11. What is katakana mostly used for?

◯ A. Words with Chinese-style meaning ◯ B. Foreign words and names ◯ C. Verb endings

LESSON 2 OF 11 · 20 MIN

The S and T Rows

Goal: Read サ シ ス セ ソ and タ チ ツ テ ト and read words like タクシー and スカート.

The S row

サ	シ	ス	セ	ソ
sa	shi	su	se	so

The T row

タ	チ	ツ	テ	ト
ta	chi	tsu	te	to

The famous look-alikes: シ and ツ, ソ and ン

シ vs ツ
Both are two short strokes and a long curve. In シ (shi) the two short strokes lie almost flat, side by side, and the long stroke sweeps upward. In ツ (tsu) the short strokes stand more upright, and the long stroke sweeps downward. Check the direction of the long stroke first.

ソ vs ン
You will meet ン (n) in lesson 5. Learn ソ (so) now: both of its strokes are written downward. In ン, the long stroke is written upward from the lower left.

Do not worry about perfect memory
Almost every learner confuses these for a while. Context helps: if you read シ in a word and it makes no sense, try ツ.

Words you can read now

JAPANESE	ROMAJI	MEANING
スキー	sukii	skiing
タクシー	takushii	taxi
テスト	tesuto	test, exam
セーター	seetaa	sweater
スーツ	suutsu	suit
アイス	aisu	ice, ice cream

サイト	saito	website
ソース	soosu	sauce
スカート	sukaato	skirt
キス	kisu	kiss

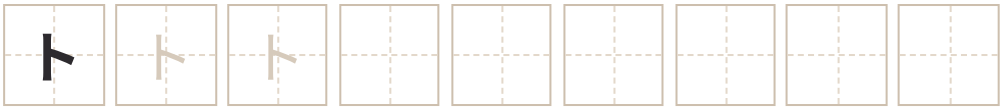
How to practise

- Say each sound out loud as you read it. You already know the sounds from hiragana, so this is only about new shapes.
- Write each new character about ten times, following a reliable stroke-order chart. Writing helps you notice the small differences between look-alike characters.
- Read the words aloud and guess what they are before checking the meaning. Most katakana words come from English, so you will often get them right.

Writing practice

Trace the grey characters, then write each one on your own. Say the sound out loud every time. Check the stroke order in this lesson's video.

sa	サ	サ	サ						
shi	シ	シ	シ						
su	ス	ス	ス						
se	セ	セ	セ						
so	ソ	ソ	ソ						
ta	タ	タ	タ						
chi	チ	チ	チ						
tsu	ツ	ツ	ツ						
te	テ	テ	テ						

to 

Check yourself

1. How do you read ト?

◯ A. to ◯ B. sa ◯ C. su

2. How do you read ス?

◯ A. se ◯ B. te ◯ C. su

3. How do you read セ?

◯ A. se ◯ B. su ◯ C. to

4. How do you read タ?

◯ A. shi ◯ B. ta ◯ C. chi

5. Which character is “so”?

◯ A. テ ◯ B. ソ ◯ C. ト

6. Which character is “chi”?

◯ A. シ ◯ B. ト ◯ C. チ

7. Which character is “te”?

◯ A. テ ◯ B. ソ ◯ C. セ

8. What does アイス mean?

◯ A. kiss ◯ B. ice, ice cream ◯ C. sauce

9. What does タクシー mean?

◯ A. taxi ◯ B. sweater ◯ C. kiss

10. What does ソース mean?

◯ A. sauce ◯ B. kiss ◯ C. taxi

11. How do you read セーター?

◯ A. sukaato ◯ B. saito ◯ C. seetaa

12. How do you read サイト?

◯ A. seetaa ◯ B. kisu ◯ C. saito

13. Which character is “tsu”?

◯ A. シ ◯ B. ソ ◯ C. ツ

LESSON 3 OF 11 · 20 MIN

The N and H Rows

Goal: Read ナ ニ ヌ ネ ノ and ハ ヒ フ ヘ ホ and words like コーヒー and ノート.

The N row

ナ	ニ	ヌ	ネ	ノ
na	ni	nu	ne	no

The H row

ハ	ヒ	フ	ヘ	ホ
ha	hi	fu	he	ho

Notes on the new shapes

ヘ is also a hiragana
ヘ (katakana) and へ (hiragana) look almost the same. Both are read “he”. You will find them in different words.

ニ is just two lines
ニ (ni) is two horizontal strokes, the top one shorter. It looks a lot like the kanji 二, which means “two”.

フ is read “fu”
Not “hu”. Like ふ in hiragana, the H row's third sound is between h and f, so it is spelt “fu”.

Words you can read now

JAPANESE	ROMAJI	MEANING
コーヒー	koohii	coffee
ノート	nooto	notebook
ネクタイ	nekutai	necktie
ナイフ	naifu	knife
ナイス	naisu	nice
ヒーター	hiitaa	heater
ヘア	hea	hair

ホース	hoosu	hose

How to practise

- Say each sound out loud as you read it. You already know the sounds from hiragana, so this is only about new shapes.
- Write each new character about ten times, following a reliable stroke-order chart. Writing helps you notice the small differences between look-alike characters.
- Read the words aloud and guess what they are before checking the meaning. Most katakana words come from English, so you will often get them right.

Writing practice

Trace the grey characters, then write each one on your own. Say the sound out loud every time. Check the stroke order in this lesson's video.



Check yourself

1. How do you read ヌ?

◯ A. nu ◯ B. hi ◯ C. ni

2. How do you read ヒ?

◯ A. hi ◯ B. he ◯ C. ha

3. How do you read ノ?

◯ A. hi ◯ B. no ◯ C. na

4. How do you read ホ?

◯ A. ni ◯ B. ho ◯ C. no

5. Which character is “ne”?

◯ A. ネ ◯ B. へ ◯ C. ナ

6. Which character is “na”?

◯ A. ニ ◯ B. ノ ◯ C. ナ

7. Which character is “he”?

◯ A. ホ ◯ B. へ ◯ C. フ

8. What does ヘア mean?

◯ A. hair ◯ B. coffee ◯ C. heater

9. What does コーヒー mean?

◯ A. knife ◯ B. necktie ◯ C. coffee

10. What does ナイス mean?

◯ A. hair ◯ B. coffee ◯ C. nice

11. How do you read ネクタイ?

◯ A. nekutai ◯ B. hoosu ◯ C. naifu

12. How do you read ホース?

◯ A. hoosu ◯ B. koohii ◯ C. naifu

13. How do you read フ?

◯ A. pu ◯ B. hu ◯ C. fu

LESSON 4 OF 11 · 20 MIN

The M and Y Rows

Goal: Read マ ミ ム メ モ and ヤ ユ ヨ and read words like マスク and ホーム.

The M row

マ	ミ	ム	メ	モ
ma	mi	mu	me	mo

The Y row

ヤ		ユ		ヨ
ya		yu		yo

Notes

The Y row has three characters
There is no “yi” or “ye” in standard Japanese, so the row has only ヤ (ya), ユ (yu) and ヨ (yo). The empty cells in the chart are on purpose.

ミ is three strokes
ミ (mi) is three short slanted strokes stacked one above the other.

ム and メ
ム (mu) is a corner with a small mark. メ (me) is a simple cross, a bit like a multiplication sign. Not to be confused with ス (su) and ナ (na).

Words you can read now

JAPANESE	ROMAJI	MEANING
マスク	masuku	mask
マイク	maiku	microphone
メモ	memo	memo, note
ミス	misu	mistake
ムース	muusu	mousse
ユーモア	yuumoa	humour
ヨーヨー	yooyoo	yo-yo

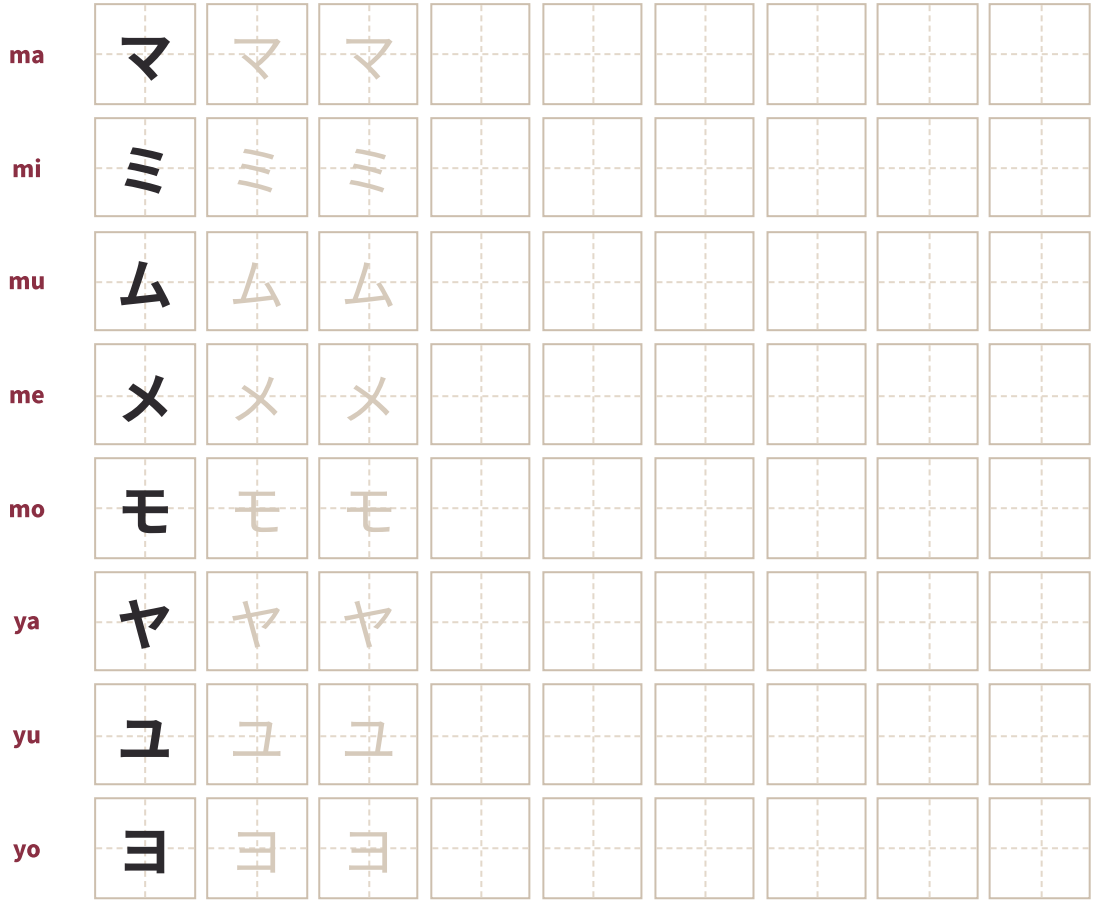
ハム	**hamu**	ham
ホーム	**hoomu**	home, station platform
モーター	**mootaa**	motor

How to practise

- Say each sound out loud as you read it. You already know the sounds from hiragana, so this is only about new shapes.
- Write each new character about ten times, following a reliable stroke-order chart. Writing helps you notice the small differences between look-alike characters.
- Read the words aloud and guess what they are before checking the meaning. Most katakana words come from English, so you will often get them right.

Writing practice

Trace the grey characters, then write each one on your own. Say the sound out loud every time. Check the stroke order in this lesson's video.



Check yourself

1. How do you read ユ?

◯ A. yo ◯ B. mi ◯ C. yu

2. How do you read ヨ?

◯ A. yo ◯ B. yu ◯ C. ya

3. How do you read マ?

◯ A. mu ◯ B. ya ◯ C. ma

4. How do you read ム?

◯ A. mi ◯ B. mu ◯ C. ya

5. Which character is “mo”?

◯ A. ユ ◯ B. ミ ◯ C. モ

6. Which character is “ya”?

◯ A. モ ◯ B. ヤ ◯ C. ム

7. Which character is “me”?

◯ A. ヨ ◯ B. ユ ◯ C. メ

8. What does モーター mean?

◯ A. mistake ◯ B. motor ◯ C. ham

9. What does マスク mean?

◯ A. humour ◯ B. mask ◯ C. home, station platform

10. What does メモ mean?

◯ A. yo-yo ◯ B. humour ◯ C. memo, note

11. How do you read ミス?

◯ A. hamu ◯ B. misu ◯ C. yooyoo

12. How do you read ホーム?

◯ A. hoomu ◯ B. masuku ◯ C. muusu

13. How many characters does the Y row have?

◯ A. Five: ヤ ユ エ ヨ イ ◯ B. Three: ヤ ユ ヨ ◯ C. Two: ヤ ヨ

LESSON 5 OF 11 · 20 MIN

The R Row, ワ, ヲ and ン

Goal: Read ラ リ ル レ ロ, ワ ヲ ン and words like ホテル, ラーメン and レストラン.

The R row

ラ ra	リ ri	ル ru	レ re	ロ ro

ワ, ヲ and ン

ワ wa	ヲ o	ン n

Notes

The Japanese R is a soft tap
It sits between English r, l and d. Touch the tip of your tongue quickly to the ridge behind your top teeth, as in the middle of “butter” in American English.

ン is a syllable of its own
ン (n) counts as one beat and only appears after other sounds, never at the start of a word. It sounds a bit like “m” before p, b or m, but you simply write ン.

ン and ソ, ワ and ウ
Compare ン (the long stroke sweeps up) with ソ (it sweeps down). ワ (wa) looks like ウ without the short stroke on top. These pairs are easy to mix up, so practise them side by side.

ヲ is rare
ヲ (o) is mostly used for the grammar particle in hiragana (を). In katakana it appears almost only in unusual cases. Learn to recognise it, and you are done.

Words you can read now

JAPANESE	ROMAJI	MEANING
ホテル	hoteru	hotel
トイレ	toire	toilet
ラーメン	raamen	ramen noodles
レモン	remon	lemon
カレー	karee	curry

レストラン	resutoran	restaurant
タオル	taoru	towel
ワイン	wain	wine
ランチ	ranchi	lunch
リモコン	rimokon	remote control
ルール	ruuru	rule

That's all 46

You now know the whole basic katakana chart. Next: the little marks that give you the extra sounds, just like in hiragana.

How to practise

- Say each sound out loud as you read it. You already know the sounds from hiragana, so this is only about new shapes.
- Write each new character about ten times, following a reliable stroke-order chart. Writing helps you notice the small differences between look-alike characters.
- Read the words aloud and guess what they are before checking the meaning. Most katakana words come from English, so you will often get them right.

Writing practice

Trace the grey characters, then write each one on your own. Say the sound out loud every time. Check the stroke order in this lesson's video.



o ヲ ヲ ヲ

n ン ン ン

Check yourself

1. How do you read ン?

◯ A. re ◯ B. ra ◯ C. n

2. How do you read リ?

◯ A. re ◯ B. ri ◯ C. n

3. How do you read ワ?

◯ A. ri ◯ B. wa ◯ C. ro

4. How do you read ロ?

◯ A. wa ◯ B. ro ◯ C. re

5. Which character is “o”?

◯ A. ラ ◯ B. ヲ ◯ C. リ

6. Which character is “re”?

◯ A. レ ◯ B. リ ◯ C. ワ

7. Which character is “ra”?

◯ A. ロ ◯ B. ラ ◯ C. ヲ

8. What does レストラン mean?

◯ A. curry ◯ B. lunch ◯ C. restaurant

9. What does カレー mean?

◯ A. curry ◯ B. hotel ◯ C. restaurant

10. What does トイレ mean?

◯ A. hotel ◯ B. wine ◯ C. toilet

11. How do you read レモン?

◯ A. remon ◯ B. raamen ◯ C. toire

12. How do you read ワイン?

◯ A. wain ◯ B. ranchi ◯ C. rimokon

13. Which of these is ン?

◯ A. ツ ◯ B. ソ ◯ C. ン

LESSON 6 OF 11 · 20 MIN

Dakuten and Handakuten: ガ ザ ダ バ パ

Goal: Read the voiced and P sounds in katakana, and read words like ビール and ゲーム.

Same idea, new shapes

Katakana uses the same two marks as hiragana. Two small strokes (dakuten, ゛) voice the consonant: カ (ka) becomes ガ (ga). A small circle (handakuten, ゜) turns the H row into the P row: ハ (ha) becomes パ (pa).

G sounds (カ row + ゛)

ガ ga	ギ gi	グ gu	ゲ ge	ゴ go

Z sounds (サ row + ゛)

ザ za	ジ ji	ズ zu	ゼ ze	ゾ zo

D sounds (タ row + ゛)

ダ da	ヂ ji	ヅ zu	デ de	ド do

B sounds (ハ row + ゛)

バ ba	ビ bi	ブ bu	ベ be	ボ bo

P sounds (ハ row + ゜)

パ pa	ピ pi	プ pu	ペ pe	ポ po

Notes

ジ and ズ
ジ is “ji” and ズ is “zu”. ヂ and ヅ are very rare and sound the same as ジ and ズ, so you will almost never need them.

Don't mix up ツ and ヅ, シ and ジ
The two small marks are the whole difference. Look at the top-right of the character.

Words you can read now

JAPANESE	ROMAJI	MEANING
ビール	biiru	beer
ゲーム	geemu	game
バス	basu	bus
ドア	doa	door
パン	pan	bread
ピアノ	piano	piano
テレビ	terebi	television
ペン	pen	pen
ゴルフ	gorufu	golf
デパート	depaato	department store
バナナ	banana	banana
ズボン	zubon	trousers
ガラス	garasu	glass (material)
ギター	gitaa	guitar
ゼロ	zero	zero

How to practise

- Say each sound out loud as you read it. You already know the sounds from hiragana, so this is only about new shapes.
- Write each new character about ten times, following a reliable stroke-order chart. Writing helps you notice the small differences between look-alike characters.
- Read the words aloud and guess what they are before checking the meaning. Most katakana words come from English, so you will often get them right.

Writing practice

Trace the grey characters, then write each one on your own. Say the sound out loud every time. Check the stroke order in this lesson's video.





Check yourself

1. How do you read ギ?

○ A. gi ○ B. be ○ C. po

2. How do you read ド?

○ A. pa ○ B. pu ○ C. do

3. How do you read ポ?

○ A. po ○ B. da ○ C. bo

4. How do you read デ?

○ A. bu ○ B. de ○ C. pu

5. Which character is “bu”?

○ A. ブ ○ B. ガ ○ C. ゼ

6. Which character is “ga”?

○ A. ザ ○ B. ガ ○ C. ゲ

7. Which character is “bo”?

○ A. ベ ○ B. ボ ○ C. ガ

8. What does デパート mean?

○ A. door ○ B. department store ○ C. bus

9. What does ピアノ mean?

◯ A. zero ◯ B. game ◯ C. piano

10. What does ペン mean?

◯ A. bus ◯ B. department store ◯ C. pen

11. How do you read ビール?

◯ A. zero ◯ B. geemu ◯ C. biiru

12. How do you read テレビ?

◯ A. terebi ◯ B. gorufu ◯ C. basu

13. What does adding two small strokes (dakuten) to カ make?

◯ A. カー (kaa) ◯ B. キ (ki) ◯ C. ガ (ga)

14. What does adding a small circle to ハ make?

◯ A. パ (pa) ◯ B. ワ (wa) ◯ C. バ (ba)

LESSON 7 OF 11 · 20 MIN

Combined Sounds: キャ シュ チョ

Goal: Read combined sounds and words like ジュース, シャワー and メニュー.

Small ャ ュ ョ

The idea is the same as in hiragana: a small ャ, ュ or ョ after an i-ending character (キ, シ, チ, ニ, ヒ, ミ, リ, ギ, ジ, ビ, ピ) blends the two into one beat. キ + ャ is キャ, read “kya”, as one beat.

Combined sounds

キャ kya	キュ kyu	キョ kyo
シャ sha	シュ shu	ショ sho
チャ cha	チュ chu	チョ cho
ニャ nya	ニュ nyu	ニョ nyo
ヒャ hya	ヒュ hyu	ヒョ hyo
ミャ mya	ミュ myu	ミョ myo
リャ rya	リュ ryu	リョ ryo
ギャ gya	ギュ gyu	ギョ gyo
ジャ ja	ジュ ju	ジョ jo
ビャ bya	ビュ byu	ビョ byo
ピャ pya	ピュ pyu	ピョ pyo

How to read them

Small means blend
Compare キヤ (ki-ya, two beats) with キャ (kya, one beat). Only the size of ヤ changes.

Spelling hints
シャ シュ ショ are “sha shu sho”, チャ チュ チョ are “cha chu cho” and ジャ ジュ ジョ are “ja ju jo”.

Words you can read now

JAPANESE	ROMAJI	MEANING
ジュース	juusu	juice
シャワー	shawaa	shower
チョコレート	chokoreeto	chocolate
シャツ	shatsu	shirt
ジャズ	jazu	jazz
メニュー	menyuu	menu
キャベツ	kyabetsu	cabbage
ニュース	nyuusu	news
シャンプー	shanpuu	shampoo
チャンス	chansu	chance
キャンプ	kyanpu	camping
ヒーロー	hiiroo	hero
ジョギング	jogingu	jogging
キャラクター	kyarakutaa	character

How to practise

- Say each sound out loud as you read it. You already know the sounds from hiragana, so this is only about new shapes.
- Write each new character about ten times, following a reliable stroke-order chart. Writing helps you notice the small differences between look-alike characters.
- Read the words aloud and guess what they are before checking the meaning. Most katakana words come from English, so you will often get them right.

Check yourself

1. How do you read ショ?

◯ A. mya ◯ B. sho ◯ C. byo

2. How do you read ピャ?

◯ A. pya ◯ B. kyo ◯ C. ja

3. How do you read ジャ?

◯ A. ja ◯ B. myu ◯ C. chu

4. How do you read ニョ?

◯ A. nyo ◯ B. kyu ◯ C. byu

5. How do you read キョ?

◯ A. myo ◯ B. kyo ◯ C. pyo

6. Which character is “chu”?

◯ A. ショ ◯ B. チュ ◯ C. ピュ

7. Which character is “myo”?

◯ A. ミョ ◯ B. シャ ◯ C. ヒュ

8. What does キャラクター mean?

◯ A. jazz ◯ B. character ◯ C. shampoo

9. What does ジョギング mean?

◯ A. character ◯ B. jogging ◯ C. menu

10. What does ジュース mean?

◯ A. juice ◯ B. character ◯ C. shampoo

11. How do you read シャンプー?

◯ A. shanpuu ◯ B. jogingu ◯ C. hiiroo

12. How do you read シャワー?

◯ A. shanpuu ◯ B. juusu ◯ C. shawaa

13. How many beats is シャ?

◯ A. Two ◯ B. Three ◯ C. One

LESSON 8 OF 11 · 25 MIN

Small ッ and Sounds for Foreign Words

Goal: Read small ッ, and read words like パーティー, フォーク and チェック.

Small ッ: a short pause

Just like small っ in hiragana, small ッ tells you to hold the next consonant for an extra beat. It is not a sound on its own. ネット is “net-to”: say the t, pause for a moment, then release it.

Words with small ッ

JAPANESE	ROMAJI	MEANING
ネット	netto	net, internet
ベッド	beddo	bed
カップ	kappu	cup
サッカー	sakkaa	soccer
チケット	chiketto	ticket
バッグ	baggu	bag
コップ	koppu	drinking glass
ストップ	sutoppu	stop
ラケット	raketto	racket

Sounds that only katakana has

Japanese has borrowed so many words that katakana has extra combinations for sounds that traditional Japanese did not have. They are made the same way as combined sounds: a normal character plus a small vowel.

You do not need to memorise all of them now. Learn to recognise the pattern: a small ィ, エ, ォ or ァ after a character changes its vowel.

Extra sounds

ティ ti	ディ di	ファ fa	フィ fi	フェ fe
フォ fo	ウィ wi	ウェ we	ウォ wo	シェ she
ジェ je	チェ che	ヴァ va		

Notes

ティ and ディ
ティ is “ti” (as in パーティー, party) and ディ is “di” (as in ディナー, dinner). Before these existed, foreign words were bent to fit older sounds.

ファ フィ フェ フォ
These are the F sounds: fa, fi, fe, fo. Remember that plain フ is already “fu”.

ヴ
ヴ (vu) shows a V sound, as in ヴァイオリン (violin). Many words with ヴ are also written with バ, ビ or ブ instead, so ヴァイオリン and バイオリン are both seen.

Words with the extra sounds

JAPANESE	ROMAJI	MEANING
パーティー	paatii	party
ディナー	dinaa	dinner
ファン	fan	fan
フィルム	firumu	film
フォーク	fooku	fork
ウェブ	webu	web
シェフ	shefu	chef
ジェット	jetto	jet
チェック	chekku	check
コンピューター	konpyuutaa	computer

ヴァイオリン	vaiorin	violin

How to practise

- Say each sound out loud as you read it. You already know the sounds from hiragana, so this is only about new shapes.
- Write each new character about ten times, following a reliable stroke-order chart. Writing helps you notice the small differences between look-alike characters.
- Read the words aloud and guess what they are before checking the meaning. Most katakana words come from English, so you will often get them right.

Check yourself

1. What does ラケット mean?

◯ A. bed ◯ B. racket ◯ C. drinking glass

2. What does カップ mean?

◯ A. cup ◯ B. net, internet ◯ C. ticket

3. What does ストップ mean?

◯ A. stop ◯ B. drinking glass ◯ C. racket

4. How do you read チケット?

◯ A. koppu ◯ B. kappu ◯ C. chiketto

5. How do you read サッカー?

◯ A. netto ◯ B. sakkaa ◯ C. kappu

6. What does ウェブ mean?

◯ A. fan ◯ B. web ◯ C. fork

7. What does コンピューター mean?

◯ A. computer ◯ B. dinner ◯ C. chef

8. What does ヴァイオリン mean?

◯ A. dinner ◯ B. chef ◯ C. violin

9. How do you read フォーク?

◯ A. fooku ◯ B. webu ◯ C. shefu

10. How do you read フィルム?

◯ A. firumu ◯ B. konpyuutaa ◯ C. jetto

11. What does the small ッ in ネット tell you to do?

◯ A. Hold the next consonant for an extra beat ◯ B. Say the vowel twice

◯ C. Skip the next character

12. How is フォーク read?

◯ A. fuoku ◯ B. fooku ◯ C. foku

LESSON 9 OF 11 · 20 MIN

Katakana in the Wild: Food and Drink

Goal: Read 17 common food and drink words, and learn how to spot the English word hiding inside.

The menu test

Katakana appears more on menus than almost anywhere else. Most of the words come from English, with Japanese pronunciation: no th, r and l the same, and a vowel after every consonant. When you get stuck, say the word aloud and think of the English word it sounds like.

Food and drink

JAPANESE	ROMAJI	MEANING
ハンバーガー	hanbaagaa	hamburger
ピザ	piza	pizza
サラダ	sarada	salad
スープ	suupu	soup
パスタ	pasuta	pasta
サンドイッチ	sandoicchi	sandwich
アイスクリーム	aisu kuriimu	ice cream
チーズ	chiizu	cheese
コーラ	koora	cola
ミルク	miruku	milk
ステーキ	suteeki	steak
ポテト	poteto	potato, fries
ヨーグルト	yooguruto	yoghurt
クッキー	kukkii	cookie
オムレツ	omuretsu	omelette
カレーライス	karee raisu	curry rice

ソーセージ	sooseeji	sausage

Tricks for decoding

Add a vowel after each consonant
Japanese cannot end most syllables in a consonant, so “cheese” becomes チーズ (chiizu) and “milk” becomes ミルク (miruku).

Long words are often joined English words
アイスクリーム is just “ice cream”. カレーライス is “curry” plus “rice”, the usual name for curry on rice.

Some words don't match English
ポテト is “potato” but also means French fries in many cafés. Not every borrowed word means exactly the same thing as in English.

How to practise

- Say each sound out loud as you read it. You already know the sounds from hiragana, so this is only about new shapes.
- Write each new character about ten times, following a reliable stroke-order chart. Writing helps you notice the small differences between look-alike characters.
- Read the words aloud and guess what they are before checking the meaning. Most katakana words come from English, so you will often get them right.

Check yourself

1. What does サンドイッチ mean?
◯ A. curry rice ◯ B. pizza ◯ C. sandwich

2. What does チーズ mean?
◯ A. cheese ◯ B. milk ◯ C. soup

3. What does ソーセージ mean?
◯ A. sausage ◯ B. ice cream ◯ C. curry rice

4. What does スープ mean?
◯ A. cookie ◯ B. cheese ◯ C. soup

5. What does カレーライス mean?
◯ A. omelette ◯ B. sandwich ◯ C. curry rice

6. How do you read ハンバーガー?
◯ A. yooguruto ◯ B. hanbaagaa ◯ C. pasuta

7. How do you read サラダ?
◯ A. miruku ◯ B. sarada ◯ C. kukkii

8. How do you read パスタ?

◯ A. piza ◯ B. sarada ◯ C. pasuta

9. Which word is “cheese”?

◯ A. サラダ ◯ B. チーズ ◯ C. ミルク

10. Why is “milk” ミルク and not just ミル?

◯ A. The k is always silent ◯ B. Japanese adds a vowel after most consonants

◯ C. It is a different language

LESSON 10 OF 11 · 20 MIN

Countries, Places and Names

Goal: Read countries and places in katakana, and spell a foreign name.

Countries

JAPANESE	ROMAJI	MEANING
アメリカ	amerika	America, USA
イギリス	igirisu	Britain, UK
カナダ	kanada	Canada
オーストラリア	oosutoraria	Australia
フランス	furansu	France
ドイツ	doitsu	Germany
イタリア	itaria	Italy
スペイン	supein	Spain
ブラジル	burajiru	Brazil
インド	indo	India
ロシア	roshia	Russia
メキシコ	mekishiko	Mexico
ニュージーランド	nyuujiirando	New Zealand

Everyday places

JAPANESE	ROMAJI	MEANING
カフェ	kafe	café
コンビニ	konbini	convenience store
スーパー	suupaa	supermarket
ホテル	hoteru	hotel

デパート	depaato	department store
プール	puuru	swimming pool

First names

JAPANESE	ROMAJI	MEANING
アレックス	arekkusu	Alex
ミカ	mika	Mika
マイク	maiku	Mike
ジョン	jon	John
エマ	ema	Emma
サラ	sara	Sarah
ケン	ken	Ken
ジェーン	jeen	Jane

Writing your own name

Sound it out, syllable by syllable
Say your name slowly and split it into Japanese beats. Alex becomes ア・レ・ッ・ク・ス: アレックス. Add ー for long vowels and ッ for doubled sounds.

There can be more than one version
Names like Emma can be written エマ or エンマ. Both are fine, because katakana spelling follows how a name sounds, not one fixed rule.

Try this

Write your own name in katakana on paper. Then try the names of three friends, your city and your favourite food. You are now using katakana the way Japanese people do.

How to practise

- Say each sound out loud as you read it. You already know the sounds from hiragana, so this is only about new shapes.
- Write each new character about ten times, following a reliable stroke-order chart. Writing helps you notice the small differences between look-alike characters.
- Read the words aloud and guess what they are before checking the meaning. Most katakana words come from English, so you will often get them right.

Check yourself

1. What does イタリア mean?

◯ A. Australia ◯ B. Germany ◯ C. Italy

2. What does ニュージーランド mean?

◯ A. Canada ◯ B. Brazil ◯ C. New Zealand

3. What does インド mean?

◯ A. Brazil ◯ B. India ◯ C. Britain, UK

4. What does アメリカ mean?

◯ A. America, USA ◯ B. India ◯ C. Canada

5. How do you read カナダ?

◯ A. supein ◯ B. kanada ◯ C. doitsu

6. How do you read イギリス?

◯ A. doitsu ◯ B. kanada ◯ C. igirisu

7. What does デパート mean?

◯ A. hotel ◯ B. department store ◯ C. café

8. What does スーパー mean?

◯ A. convenience store ◯ B. supermarket ◯ C. department store

9. How do you read カフェ?

◯ A. hoteru ◯ B. depaato ◯ C. kafe

10. How is アレックス read?

◯ A. alexs ◯ B. arekkusu ◯ C. arekusu

LESSON 11 OF 11 · 25 MIN

Reading Practice and Review

Goal: Read short Japanese sentences with both scripts aloud with confidence.

Both scripts together

Real Japanese mixes scripts in one sentence. Hiragana carries the grammar, katakana carries the borrowed words. When you see a katakana word inside a hiragana sentence, it is almost always a noun that came from another language.

Sentences to read aloud

Sentence 1	わたしは アレックスです。 **Watashi wa Arekkusu desu.** I am Alex.
Sentence 2	コーヒーを ください。 **Koohii o kudasai.** Coffee, please.
Sentence 3	トイレは どこですか。 **Toire wa doko desu ka.** Where is the toilet?
Sentence 4	ホテルは あそこです。 **Hoteru wa asoko desu.** The hotel is over there.
Sentence 5	ラーメンが すきです。 **Raamen ga suki desu.** I like ramen.
Sentence 6	サッカーを します。 **Sakkaa o shimasu.** I play soccer.
Sentence 7	ビールと ワインを ください。 **Biiru to wain o kudasai.** Beer and wine, please.
Sentence 8	カタカナが よめます！ **Katakana ga yomemasu!** I can read katakana!

A mini menu to read

JAPANESE	ROMAJI	MEANING
ハンバーガーセット	hanbaagaa setto	hamburger set
チーズピザ	chiizu piza	cheese pizza
コーヒー	koohii	coffee
オレンジジュース	orenji juusu	orange juice
チョコレートケーキ	chokoreeto keeki	chocolate cake

Where to go next

You can now read both kana scripts, which is the foundation for everything else in Japanese. Next, take the First Conversations course to use what you know in real situations, and keep an eye on signs, packaging and menus. Every one is free reading practice.

Check yourself

1. How do you read コーヒーを ください?

◯ A. koohii wa kudasai ◯ B. kohi o kudasai ◯ C. koohii o kudasai

2. What does トイレは どこですか mean?

◯ A. Where is the toilet? ◯ B. This is a hotel ◯ C. I like the toilet

3. What does ラーメンが すきです mean?

◯ A. Ramen, please ◯ B. I eat ramen ◯ C. I like ramen

4. In ホテルは あそこです, what does あそこ mean?

◯ A. over there ◯ B. tomorrow ◯ C. right here

5. In a Japanese sentence, katakana is mostly used for...

◯ A. Borrowed words and foreign names ◯ B. Particles like は and を ◯ C. Verb endings

6. How is ビールと ワインを ください read?

◯ A. biiru to wain o kudasai ◯ B. biru to wain wa kudasai ◯ C. biiru to wain o kudasu

Answer key

Lesson 1: Meet Katakana: Vowels and the K Row

1. C. e
2. C. u
3. C. o
4. B. ki
5. B. カ
6. C. コ
7. C. ク
8. B. OK
9. C. key
10. B. kaa
11. B. Foreign words and names

Lesson 2: The S and T Rows

1. A. to
2. C. su
3. A. se
4. B. ta
5. B. ソ
6. C. チ
7. A. テ
8. B. ice, ice cream
9. A. taxi
10. A. sauce
11. C. seetaa
12. C. saito
13. C. ツ

Lesson 3: The N and H Rows

1. A. nu
2. A. hi
3. B. no
4. B. ho
5. A. ネ
6. C. ナ
7. B. へ
8. A. hair
9. C. coffee
10. C. nice
11. A. nekutai
12. A. hoosu
13. C. fu

Lesson 4: The M and Y Rows

1. C. yu
2. A. yo
3. C. ma
4. B. mu
5. C. モ
6. B. ヤ
7. C. メ
8. B. motor
9. B. mask
10. C. memo, note
11. B. misu
12. A. hoomu
13. B. Three: ヤ ユ ヨ

Lesson 5: The R Row, ワ, ヲ and ン

1. C. n
2. B. ri
3. B. wa
4. B. ro
5. B. ヲ
6. A. レ
7. B. ラ
8. C. restaurant
9. A. curry
10. C. toilet
11. A. remon
12. A. wain
13. C. ン

Lesson 6: Dakuten and Handakuten: ガ ザ ダ バ パ

1. A. gi
2. C. do
3. A. po
4. B. de
5. A. ブ
6. B. ガ
7. B. ボ
8. B. department store
9. C. piano
10. C. pen
11. C. biiru
12. A. terebi
13. C. ガ (ga)
14. A. パ (pa)

Lesson 7: Combined Sounds: キャ シュ チョ

1. B. sho
2. A. pya
3. A. ja
4. A. nyo
5. B. kyo
6. B. チュ
7. A. ミョ
8. B. character
9. B. jogging
10. A. juice
11. A. shanpuu
12. C. shawaa
13. C. One

Lesson 8: Small ッ and Sounds for Foreign Words

1. B. racket
2. A. cup
3. A. stop
4. C. chiketto
5. B. sakkaa
6. B. web
7. A. computer
8. C. violin
9. A. fooku
10. A. firumu
11. A. Hold the next consonant for an extra beat
12. B. fooku

Lesson 9: Katakana in the Wild: Food and Drink

1. C. sandwich
2. A. cheese
3. A. sausage
4. C. soup
5. C. curry rice
6. B. hanbaagaa
7. B. sarada
8. C. pasuta
9. B. チーズ
10. B. Japanese adds a vowel after most consonants

Lesson 10: Countries, Places and Names

1. C. Italy
2. C. New Zealand
3. B. India
4. A. America, USA
5. B. kanada
6. C. igirisu
7. B. department store
8. B. supermarket
9. C. kafe
10. B. arekkusu

Lesson 11: Reading Practice and Review

1. C. koohii o kudasai
2. A. Where is the toilet?
3. C. I like ramen
4. A. over there
5. A. Borrowed words and foreign names
6. A. biiru to wain o kudasai

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